

5. Might I be in pain but not know that I'm in pain?

An identity theorist agrees with the physicalist point of view that the mind is physically identical to the brain, and each type of mental state is identical to a given state of the brain- the sensation of being 'in pain' is a physical, biological state the mind/brain can be in.

This can mean that also having conscious knowledge of this pain is a separate state of mind- it is possible to be in a state where you are 'in pain' without conscious knowledge of it.

Normally though, the whole evolutionary point of pain is that we 'feel' and know about it straight away- the instant you feel a pinch on your skin, C-fibres involuntarily fire and send signals to the brain, putting the mind into the conscious state of 'in pain' and giving you conscious knowledge of this, so that you fix whatever is causing the bodily harm which is hurting you.

However, a soldier in battle may be so distracted that he does not 'feel' he has been shot, until he looks down and consciously realises he is bleeding.

Chalmers distinguishes this as the difference between '*phenomenal consciousness*' of what the pain feels like, and the '*psychological consciousness*' which involves the cognitive processing and attention required when you notice you are bleeding and need medical attention. As soon as the soldier 'knows' (becomes psychologically conscious) of the pain, he bandages it- however he did not 'feel it' until way after being shot (which is when he should have normally 'felt' it), so he was not initially phenomenally conscious of it.

Traditionally, we gain knowledge of the *external* world through our five external senses which give us information about the world around us. Arguably we have an internal 'sixth sense' which enables us to experience and gain knowledge from the *internal* world inside our minds, through *introspection*.

According to *Descartes*, this ability to sense and understand our own internal worlds is infallible, and provides us with incorrigible self-knowledge of our own mental states. However the fact that the soldier did not instantly sense the state he was in disproves this- obviously his mind failed to provide him with conscious self-knowledge, so it is not a perfect mechanism.

This phenomenon could be explained scientifically. It could be argued something like adrenaline overrode the C-fiber signals from the skin to the brain, preventing the soldier's brain from reaching the state of 'in pain' the instant he was shot. In this case, according to an Identity theorist, the soldier is simply not in pain, as it did not reach that state.

In this case, the soldier did not know he's in pain, but he was also paradoxically not actually in pain until he became aware of it, which does not provide a satisfying answer to the question of the possibility of being in pain without knowing it.

Intuitively though, it seems impossible for the brain to not unconsciously react in any way to such pain- perhaps if the soldier was to get his brain scanned with an MRI in the state he was in when he was unaware he was shot, then it would show signs of the brain being unconsciously 'aware' of the C-fibers firing, as otherwise this could be a physiological issue with his nervous system.

This questions our abilities to experience, and also *recognise*, qualia- as well as the reliability of self-knowledge and introspection. Introspection is not an automatic process running constantly in the background of our minds. If, after being shot and not realising, the soldier actively

practiced introspection to try and internally sense, think about, and gain knowledge of any pain he may have in his body, then it is possible this introspection may have brought on the awareness, and consequently the feeling, of the pain.

Since introspection inherently requires active conscious thought and cognition, harm can be inflicted to the body without the person realising it- if introspection was a constant, infallible activity, we would be guaranteed to feel and be aware of all pain instantly. In the soldier example, there exist other psychological distractions that make it harder to feel things.

Subsequently- if, like according to Identity Theory, the mind is just the brain and introspection is just a 'self-scanning process' of the nervous system (Armstrong), this 'scanner' is not a perfect mechanism and can malfunction, just like any other physical device that can 'scan' its environment.

A malfunction of this scanner could be described as a 'hallucination', defined broadly as a 'false sensory perception'. When committing introspection and 'scanning' our own minds, there is the possibility for false positives as well as negatives- we can falsely psychologically perceive something that is not there, or falsely perceive the absence of it.

It makes sense to assume that you would always realise when you get shot, since it is your body, and it would be hard to ignore such a volume of pain. This misleading notion that pain may stem from a 'folk' understanding of psychology (Churchland), where most people don't recognise the nuances of the mind.